MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 3: Poetry - Sonnets 130 and 144

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Sonnet 130 questions false idealisation, while Sonnet 144 dramatises the insecurity and moral language of jealous desire.

Start with a picture

Someone says, “Your eyes are stars.” Another person asks whether affection really needs impossible comparisons. Now imagine a jealous speaker building a story from fear without proof. These poems examine different problems in the way love is described.

1. Sonnet 130: refusing exaggerated praise

The mistress’s eyes are not suns; her lips do not surpass coral, and her appearance and voice do not match idealised poetic comparisons. The poem repeatedly refuses the conventional **blazon**, a sequence of comparisons describing a beloved’s features.

This does not mean the speaker has discovered that love is worthless. The couplet affirms the value of his affection without the false comparison. The poem attacks a language of praise that can turn the beloved into an impossible collection of beautiful objects.

Read its movement

The first quatrain rejects visual comparisons. The second continues the examination of conventional beauty. The third turns to voice, movement, and the contrast with a goddess. The final couplet reframes the preceding refusals as a case for affection without dishonest inflation.

Keep the tension

The poem can be funny and affectionate, but its speaker still evaluates a woman through physical details. Calling it perfectly free from gendered judgement would be too simple. Analyse how the comic method works and what its limits are.

2. Sonnet 144: two loves

The speaker imagines two loves as opposing spirits: a comforting male figure and a troubling female figure. Angel-and-devil language turns a complicated triangle into a moral drama.

These are the speaker’s classifications. The poem does not establish that a man is objectively good or that a woman is inherently evil. Its vocabulary also participates in gendered and religious assumptions that can be questioned.

What does the speaker actually know?

He suspects that one beloved has drawn the other away from him. Much of the poem is built from conjecture rather than confirmed observation. Its ending continues that insecurity instead of resolving everything with reliable evidence.

Imagine seeing two friends talking privately and immediately assuming betrayal. The example shows how anxiety can organise an interpretation; it is not a literal event from the sonnet.

Imagery and double meanings

Religious images of salvation, temptation, and hell also carry sexual implications. **Ambiguity** allows moral fear and erotic jealousy to overlap. Explain both levels rather than reducing every word to one dictionary meaning.

3. Compare the poems

Sonnet 130 challenges conventional idealisation with deliberate plainness and comic reversal. Sonnet 144 shows the speaker’s attempt to interpret desire through sharp oppositions that cannot eliminate doubt. Both ask how language shapes the people it seems merely to describe.

Both sonnets follow a fourteen-line English form and closing couplet. Their conclusions do different things: one affirms affection against false comparison; the other leaves an unresolved question of trust.

4. Be careful about biography

“Dark Lady” and “Fair Youth” are customary critical labels. Do not identify the speakers or addressees with named historical people as if that identity were proven. A useful essay can analyse desire and gender without solving an unknown biography.

Quick check

1. What does Sonnet 130 resist? **Exaggerated conventions of ideal beauty.**
2. Is the jealousy in Sonnet 144 confirmed by an objective narrator? **No.**
3. Are “angel” and “devil” neutral descriptions? **No; they express a morally charged viewpoint.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain conventions of ideal praise.
2. Follow Sonnet 130 towards its couplet.
3. Analyse the moral imagery in Sonnet 144.

4. Distinguish suspicion from confirmed knowledge.
5. Compare what each conclusion establishes or leaves open.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not interpret the words dark or evil as an objective judgement about a racial group, or treat the speaker’s jealousy as proof of events outside the poem.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How do Sonnets 130 and 144 question the reliability of language about love?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Sonnet 130 exposes the distance between a real beloved and inherited conventions of praise. Its repeated negative comparisons frustrate the expectation that every feature will be transformed into something impossibly beautiful. The apparent refusal of admiration creates a comic problem that the final couplet resolves differently: affection can be valuable without the exaggeration of conventional poetic representation.

The effect depends on the structure of the sonnet. Quatrain after quatrain dismantles another part of an idealised picture, while the couplet asks the reader to reconsider the purpose of those refusals. The speaker’s honesty becomes an alternative claim to poetic distinction. Nevertheless, the poem still distributes power through a male voice describing a woman’s body. Its resistance to one convention does not place it outside all gendered conventions.

Sonnet 144 approaches unreliability from another direction. Instead of rejecting an inherited language, the speaker uses religious oppositions to narrate jealousy. The imagined angel and devil give emotional uncertainty a strong moral shape. Yet the repeated lack of direct knowledge undermines the certainty such classifications appear to offer. Sexual double meanings further disturb a clean separation between spiritual allegory and bodily desire.

The comparison consequently needs more than a statement that both poems concern imperfect love. One poem tests extravagant praise; the other exposes the insecure interpretation of relationships. Both demonstrate that a lyric voice constructs a view rather than reporting an unquestionable reality. This distinction provides a strong basis for analysing gender, imagery, and the relation between feeling and evidence.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Compare Sonnet 130’s treatment of the mistress with that of a conventional Petrarchan sonnet.
2. Analyse how honesty and humour combine to convey true affection in Sonnet 130.
3. Examine the “two loves” conflict in Sonnet 144 and its moral implications.
4. Discuss jealousy and temptation as depicted through imagery in Sonnet 144.
5. Explore how both sonnets use religious or comic imagery to challenge poetic conventions.